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Influencer Authenticity vs. AI-Generated Content: An Empirical Study on Consumer Skepticism, Brand Credibility, and Purchase Intention in the Age of Generative AI

Under-Graduate Minor Project Report
(Digital Marketing)

BACHELOR OF TECHNOLOGY

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March 2026

ABSTRACT

Influencer marketing is now a major part of digital advertising. The global market was worth about $32.55 billion in 2025 and is expected to grow to $52 billion by 2028. However, new AI tools like ChatGPT, Midjourney, and Sora are causing problems in the industry. Even though brands and influencers use these tools to make content faster, many shoppers are starting to doubt content that doesn't feel "real." Research shows that only 15% of people trust AI-made influencer posts, and nearly one-third say they are less likely to interact with brands that use AI in their ads.

This study looks at how several factors like how "real" an influencer seems, if people know AI was used, how honest the post is, and how close followers feel to an influencer affect whether people doubt influencer marketing today. The study uses several established academic theories to explain this. It looks at how "consumer doubt" acts as a middle step between the influencer's style and two main results: whether people trust the brand and whether they actually buy the product. The research suggests six main ideas (hypotheses) about how these factors lead to doubt and how that doubt changes how people behave.

The study uses a survey-based method with a list of 26 "agree or disagree" questions taken from previous research. Information will be gathered from Indian internet users aged 18 and older using an online Google Form shared on social media. The data will be analyzed using various math and coding tools, including Python and a software called SmartPLS 4.0, to check for patterns and ensure the results are reliable.

So far, the project has finished the full planning model, created the six main ideas to test, and reviewed over 20 recent academic papers from 2024 to 2026. The survey questions are also finished and ready. The survey will be tested on a small group (a pilot test) in the next few weeks. The goal of this research is to show how to balance using AI while still keeping things feeling "real," which will help marketers, brand managers, and social media designers

LIST OF TABLES

Table No	Table Title	Page No
2.1	Constructs' Operational Definitions	7
2.2	Summary of Hypotheses	9

LIST OF FIGURES

Figure No	Figure Title	Page No
2.1	Conceptual Model of Influencer Authenticity, AI Content, and Consumer Behaviour	6

Contents

			Page No
Abstract			i
List Of Tables			ii
List Of Figures			iii
Chapter 1		**INTRODUCTION**	
	1.1	Introduction to the Area of Work	1
	1.2	Present-Day Scenario	1
	1.3	Need for the Research Study	1
	1.4	Problem Statement	1
	1.5	Research Objectives	2
	1.6	Target Specifications and Significance	2
Chapter 2		**LITERATURE REVIEW**	
	2.1	Present State and Recent Developments	3
	2.2	Theoretical Foundations	3
	2.3	Influencer Authenticity and Consumer Behaviour	4
	2.4	AI-Generated Content and Consumer Perceptions	4
	2.5	Consumer Skepticism and Persuasion Knowledge	5
	2.6	Parasocial Relationships in the AI Age	5
	2.7	Conceptual Model	6
	2.8	Hypotheses Development	7
Chapter 3		**PROPOSED METHODOLOGY**	
	3.1	Research Approach and Study Design	10
	3.2	Data Collection Method	10
	3.3	Sample Design	10
	3.4	Instrument / Questionnaire Development	10
	3.5	Statistical Tools and Methods	11
Chapter 4		**WORK DONE SO FAR AND OUTCOMES**	
	4.1	Questionnaire Development and Sources	12
	4.2	Summary of Work Completed	12
Chapter 5		**FUTURE SCOPE OF WORK**	13
REFERENCES			14
ANNEXURES			16

CHAPTER 1

INTRODUCTION

1.1 Introduction to the Area of Work

Influencer marketing is now a major power in digital advertising. It has changed how brands talk to customers by using trusted social media personalities. The global market for this industry was worth about $32.55 billion in 2025 and is expected to reach $52 billion by 2028. Unlike old-fashioned ads, influencer marketing works because people think it is "real." Followers listen to influencers because they believe the content shows true opinions and honest advice. However, things are changing quickly. New AI tools like ChatGPT for writing, Midjourney for pictures, and Sora for video are completely changing how influencers make their posts.

1.2 Present-Day Scenario

Digital marketing in 2025–2026 is in a strange spot. For the first time, there is more AI-written content online than human-written content. By 2026, almost 40% of video ads will likely use AI. Even so, people are starting to push back. Only 15% of shoppers truly trust AI influencers, and about one-third say they are less likely to buy from a brand that uses AI in its ads. India is a very important place to study this because it has over 820 million internet users and one of the fastest-growing markets in the world.

1.3 Need for the Research Study

Even though AI is being used everywhere in influencer marketing, we don't fully understand how people feel when they realize a post was made by AI. Most current research only looks at "virtual" influencers (robots/animations), not real humans using AI tools. Also, no study has combined all the important factors like honesty about AI use, how "real" the person feels, and the bond between the follower and the influencer into one big project. Finally, there isn't enough research on Indian consumers, even though India is a huge market with new laws about digital data and transparency.

1.4 Problem Statement

How do an influencer's "realness", the user's knowledge of AI, the honesty of the post, and the fan's relationship with the influencer affect doubt? Furthermore, how does that doubt change whether a person trusts the brand or wants to buy the product?

1.5 Research Objectives

The study looks to achieve the following objectives:

- Look at how "realness," AI awareness, honesty, and fan relationships lead to consumer doubt.
- Analyze how that doubt acts as a middle step that changes brand trust and sales.
- Find out which of these factors are the strongest at causing or stopping doubt.

1.5.1 Research Questions

- RQ1: How do these different factors change how much a consumer doubts an influencer?
- RQ2: Does having more doubt lead to lower brand trust and fewer sales?
- RQ3: Which specific traits of an influencer or their post are the biggest predictors of doubt?

1.6 Target Specifications and Significance

The results of this study will help marketers, brand managers, social media companies, and lawmakers. By knowing what causes doubt, professionals can create better strategies for telling the truth about AI and building trust. In India, the results will also help people understand how to follow new laws regarding AI transparency. Overall, the study will provide a "how-to" guide for successful influencer marketing in a world full of AI.

CHAPTER 2

LITERATURE REVIEW

2.1 Present State and Recent Developments

Significant changes have been made to influencer marketing with the advent of artificial intelligence technologies. A 2025 meta-analysis of 251 studies (Lee et al.) confirms that influencer marketing is a powerful driver of consumer behavior. The study, which had extracted over 1,500 effect sizes, establishes persuasion knowledge as the fundamental mechanism that links content characteristics to marketing success. Hence, this provides a standard empirical foundation for the influence of digital creators. Further, post characteristics (informational value, hedonic value), follower characteristics (social identity), and influencer characteristics (credibility, expertise) were found to influence transactional as well as non-transactional outcomes of marketing.

Meanwhile, the virtual influencer market size was valued at 4.6 billion US dollars in 2024 and according to research published in JTAER (2025), it is expected to record a CAGR of 38.9% in the future. A research published in California Management Review (2025) found that currently, audiences send 3.9 authenticity signals on average for judging content credibility. Moreover, According to the HubSpot State of Marketing Report (2026), 61% of marketers believe that marketing is witnessing its biggest disruption in 20 years with the advent of AI. Hootsuite's Social Trends Report (2026) found that for the first time ever, articles created using AI have surpassed content created by humans on the internet.

2.2 Theoretical Foundations

2.2.1 Persuasion Knowledge Model (PKM)

The Persuasion Knowledge Model, as presented by Friestad and Wright (1994), explains the process through which consumers generate and utilize persuasion knowledge to make sense of, evaluate, and respond to persuasion attempts. When consumers detect a persuasion attempt, they engage in coping strategies such as skepticism. This study finds that consumers will have increased skepticism toward an influencer when they become aware of AI being used as a persuasive attempt to increase their persuasion knowledge. Lee et al.'s (2025), JAM's meta-analytic review of 251 studies showed that persuasion knowledge negatively influenced influencer credibility; in addition, skeptics were shown to mediate between the content characteristics and marketing outcomes.

2.2.2 Source Credibility Theory

Source Credibility Theory, introduced by Hovland, Janis, and Kelley (1953) and further modified by Ohanian (1990), states that the persuasiveness of communication is a function of the perceived expertise, trustworthiness, and attractiveness of the communicator. AI influencers may affect the perceived trustworthiness of the content creator, with consumers doubting whether the influencer really endorses the expressed views. Ujjainwala (2025) empirically proved the significance of Source Credibility Theory by showing the negative impact of AI influencers on perceived authenticity and trust compared to human influencers.

2.2.3 Parasocial Interaction Theory

The Parasocial Interaction Theory was proposed by Horton and Wohl (1956). It is based on the concept of one-sided emotional relationships that an audience forms with media personalities. Within the context of social media, Parasocial Relationships (PSRs) occur between influencers and their followers based on repeated exposure to personal information, self-disclosure, and intimacy (Dibble et al., 2016). Another research paper published in the journal Nature Humanities & Social Sciences Communications, Liu & Zheng (2024) came to similar conclusions that authenticity influences Parasocial Relationships (PSR) which positively influences purchase intention and brand credibility, whilst persuasion knowledge negatively influences the relationship between PSR and brand credibility.

2.2.4 Stimulus-Organism-Response (S-O-R) Framework

The S-O-R framework provides the overarching structural logic for the conceptual model. The theory is largely based on the S-O-R model proposed by Mehrabian and Russell (1974), in which stimuli in the environment (S) cause a state in the organism (O), which in turn leads to a response (R) by that organism.In this study, influencer and content characteristics are considered as stimuli, whereas skepticism is considered as the organismic state, and brand credibility and purchase intention are considered as behavioural responses. Mediation logic supports this study in using skepticism as a key mediating factor, instead of direct effects from content characteristics to outcomes (Bigné, Andreu & Gnoth, 2005).

2.3 Influencer Authenticity and Consumer Behaviour

The consumer perception of influencer authenticity has been widely analyzed as a determinant for the successful outcome of the marketing campaign. Authenticity is based on genuineness and originality along with the congruence of the influencer's personality with their self-values (Morhart et al., 2015). Liu and Zheng (2024) found that the informative value, authenticity, and homophily of influencer content have a positive effect on parasocial relations. The relationships between parasocial connections, purchase intention, and credibility have been studied, with a 2025 study in MDPI offering an explanation for the paradox of the negative effect of trust on purchase intention in influencer marketing, which occurs when a perfect post leads consumers to activate their persuasion knowledge and turn their trust into skepticism.

2.4 AI-Generated Content and Consumer Perceptions

A between subjects study by Ujjainwala (2025), using 320 participants who were all social media users tested how different levels of involvement from AI based influencers would effect perceived authenticity as well as perceived trust in an organization. Results showed that the use of an AI-based influencer resulted in a significant reduction in both perceived authenticity and trust in a brand when compared to a human influencer. Explicatory AI disclosures amplified these effects, although digital literacy moderated these relationships. A research published in Journal of Theoretical and Applied Electronic Commerce Research (JTAER, 2025) with 414 survey responses found that credibility, informative value, and human-likeness are key factors for consumer engagement and purchase intention with AI-based virtual influencers. Entertainment value and attractiveness were not found to have a direct influence on purchase intention. This suggests that cognitive evaluations dominate over hedonic evaluations in AI influencer contexts.

2.5 Consumer Skepticism and Persuasion Knowledge

In a study by IJRISS (2025), macro-influencer content considerably stimulates persuasion knowledge, while UGC content does not. Transparency increases consumers trust for influencers. Eisend & Tarrahi (2022) state that these negative underlying motives lead to negative attitudes toward advertising and the brand, as well as purchase intentions. In addition, studies by Evans et al. (2017) and Woodroof et al. (2020) revealed that transparency in disclosing brand partnerships increases credibility, which could be a potential mechanism for mitigating skepticism.

2.6 Parasocial Relationships in the AI Age

In a study published by Discover Sustainability (2025) of Springer, on the topic of TikTok users, it was found that AI influencers are capable of creating an emotional connection, at times more effectively than human influencers, to achieve community cohesion. However, the issue of long-term credibility cannot be overlooked. In a study published by the British Journal of Management (Davlembayeva, 2025), it was pointed out that attributes of virtual influencers, which play a crucial role in improving followers' engagement, need more research. Farivar, Wang, and Turel (2024) found that parasocial intimacy results in reduced defensive processing of promotional content

2.7 Conceptual Model

On the basis of the reviewed literature and theoretical foundations, a conceptual model has been developed to explain how influencer and content characteristics influence consumer behavioural outcomes through the mediating effect of consumer skepticism. In this conceptual model, Perceived Authenticity (PA), AI Content Awareness (ACA), Content Transparency (CT), and Parasocial Relationship (PSR) are considered independent variables. These variables are assumed to influence Consumer Skepticism (CS) as a mediating variable. Consumer Skepticism, in turn, is assumed to influence Brand Credibility (BC) and Purchase Intention (PI) negatively. The conceptual model follows a S-O-R model in which influencer/content characteristics are considered stimuli variables, consumer skepticism an organismic variable, and brand credibility and purchase intention behavioural response variables.

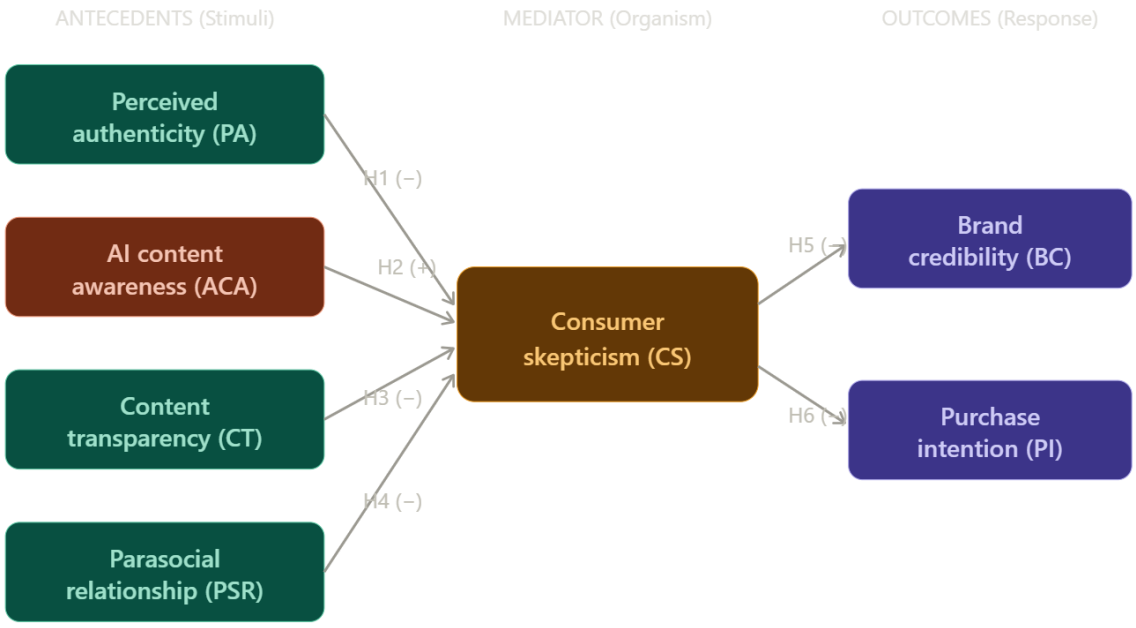


Table 2.1: Constructs' Operational Definitions

Construct	Definition in the Study
Perceived Authenticity (PA)	The extent to which consumers perceive influencer's content as original, genuine, and reflective of influencer's true opinions and personality.
AI Content Awareness (ACA)	Consumer awareness or suspicion that influencer content has been created or substantially assisted by AI tools.
Content Transparency (CT)	The degree to which influencers or brands disclose the use of AI tools, sponsorships, or any other non-organic element in producing and distributing their content.
Parasocial Relationship (PSR)	A one-sided emotional bond and sense of intimacy that a follower develops with an influencer as a result of repeated exposure to their content.
Consumer Skepticism (CS)	Consumers' attitudes toward the authenticity and credibility of the content promoted by influencers
Brand Credibility (BC)	Consumer's perception of the credibility, expertise, authority, and trustworthiness of the promoted brand impacted by the influencer's endorsement of the brand.
Purchase Intention (PI)	Consumer's self-reported likelihood of purchasing a product/service after exposure to influencer marketing content.

2.8 Hypotheses Development

2.8.1 Perception of Authenticity and Consumer Skepticism

Social media influencers perceived as authentic will cause consumers to have decreased skepticism towards the influencer. Influencers who provide cues of authenticity such as; stories, unpolished content, consistency with their promotions, create a belief within consumers of authenticity. That belief in authenticity creates emotional bonds with the products or services being promoted by the said influencer and also creates a defensive response to marketing campaigns (Morhart et al., 2015). Thus, Influencers perceived as authentic will create a low level of persuasion knowledge activation. In addition, research conducted by Liu & Zheng (2024) showed that people who perceive influencers as authentic experience a greater amount of positive emotion associated with a particular brand.

H1: Perceived authenticity has a significant negative effect on consumer skepticism.

2.8.2 AI Content Awareness and Consumer Skepticism

When the consumer is aware that the content is AI-generated, persuasion knowledge activation is triggered, according to Friestad & Wright (1994). The consumer becomes aware that the human component is removed. Thus, they are more skeptical about the influencer's true

opinions. Ujjainwala (2025) discovered that AI influencers result in a significant decrease in perceived authenticity and trust compared to their human counterparts

H2: AI content awareness has a significant positive effect on consumer skepticism.

2.8.3 Content Transparency and Consumer Skepticism

When the AI influencer is transparent about the AI content, skepticism is reduced. Evans et al. (2017) and Woodroof et al. (2020) discovered that transparent disclosure of the influencer's partnership with the brand increases credibility. The PKM theory indicates that when the consumer is aware of the AI content, they do not experience the discovery shock.

H3: Content transparency has a significant negative effect on consumer skepticism.

2.8.4 Parasocial Relationship and Consumer Skepticism

A strong parasocial relationship can reduce consumer skepticism; consumers who feel a strong emotional connection to influencers are less likely to process the influencer's content from a PK perspective. Farivar, Wang, and Turel (2024) observed that parasocial intimacy is associated with less defensive processing of promotional content.

H4: Parasocial relationship strength has a significant negative effect on consumer skepticism.

2.8.5 Consumer Skepticism and Brand Credibility

Consumer skepticism is not limited to influencer content; consumers can also become skeptical of the brand when they do not trust the influencer due to perceived inauthenticity.According to Friestad & Wright's Perceived Knowledge Model (PKM) (1994), as well as Erdem & Swiat's (2004) study, consumer scepticism leads to a negative attitude toward a brand based on consumer perceptions of the brand's motives.

H5: Consumer skepticism has a significant negative effect on brand credibility.

2.8.6 Consumer Skepticism and Purchase Intention

High levels of consumer skepticism are associated with lower intention to purchase. The JAMS meta-analysis (Lee et al., 2025) confirmed that, out of 251 studies, skepticism reduces purchase intention, with persuasion knowledge as a mediator between content characteristics and behavioral outcomes.

H6: Consumer skepticism has a significant negative effect on purchase intention.

Table 2.2: Summary of Hypotheses

Hyp.	Statement	Direction
H1	Perceived Authenticity has a significant negative effect on Consumer Skepticism.	−
H2	AI Content Awareness has a significant positive effect on Consumer Skepticism.	+
H3	Content Transparency has a significant negative effect on Consumer Skepticism.	−
H4	Parasocial Relationship has a significant negative effect on Consumer Skepticism.	−
H5	Consumer Skepticism has a significant negative effect on Brand Credibility.	−
H6	Consumer Skepticism has a significant negative effect on Purchase Intention.	−

CHAPTER 3

PROPOSED METHODOLOGY

3.1 Research Approach and Study Design

This research follows a quantitative approach that involves testing of hypotheses. The methodology can be considered "descriptive" in relation to the description of attitudes of consumers towards AI and influencers, and "causal" when analyzing the causation between various variables that lead to consumer uncertainty and purchase intention.

3.2 Data Collection Method

The information will be gathered using an online survey on Google Forms. This survey will be shared through social media (Instagram, LinkedIn, WhatsApp), email, and text messages for people to fill out themselves.

3.3 Sample Design

Target Group: Indian internet users aged 18 and older who follow at least one influencer and have seen influencer ads in the last six months.

How People are Chosen: A "convenience" method (asking people who are easily reachable) and a "snowball" method (asking participants to share the survey with others).

Number of People: At least 200 people for the main study; a small test group of 30–50 people will be used first for a pilot study.

Who is being Studied: Individual social media users in India.

3.4 Instrument / Questionnaire Development

The survey is a formal list of questions where people rate how much they agree or disagree on a scale of 1 to 5. These questions are based on proven scientific scales used in previous research to measure things like doubt, relationships with influencers, brand trust, and the intent to buy. You can find the full list of questions in Annexure I.

3.5 Statistical Tools and Methods

Tools: Python (a coding language) will be used to organize data and check for patterns. A software called SmartPLS 4.0 will be used for more complex modeling.

Methods: Several analyses will be conducted to make sure the data is reliable and accurate. These include correlation analysis to examine relationships between variables, regression analysis to identify the factors that influence behaviou, and bootstrapping techniques to confirm the solidify the results.

CHAPTER 4

WORK DONE SO FAR AND OUTCOMES

4.1 Questionnaire Development and Sources

The survey tool was developed based on a conceptual framework and have questions modified from recognised studies. It comprises a total of 26 items that assess concepts like perceived authenticity, awareness of AI-generated content, and transparency of content. Furthermore, the survey examines parasocial relationships, doubt among consumers, brand credibility, and intentions to purchase, depending on different validated scales from earlier research. The complete version of the questionnaire is available in Annexure I.

4.2 Summary of Work Completed

- A thorough literature review has been done, including over 20 references from publications released between 2024 and 2026.
- Four well-known theories were combined into a conceptual model (PKM, Source Credibility, Parasocial Interaction, S-O-R). Six testable hypotheses have been developed with theoretical justification
- Six testable hypotheses formulated with theoretical justification.
- The survey instrument was created using Likert-scale items that were modified from validated scales
- Google Form created and ready for distribution.
- A pilot study with a goal of 30–50 replies will be carried out in the upcoming weeks.

CHAPTER 5

FUTURE SCOPE OF WORK

The second semester's remaining assignments are organized as follows. Before the main data collection, a pilot research with 30–50 respondents will be carried out in the first few weeks to set item clarity, examine internal consistency of constructs, and identify problematic issues. To validate the measurement model, the pilot data will be studied using item-total correlations, Cronbach's alpha, and first SmartPLS modeling.

With a goal of 200–400+ replies, the primary data collection will start after the pilot validation and be shared via email, messaging apps, and social media. Three stages will comprise the main study analysis: regression modeling, comprehensive PLS-SEM analysis using SmartPLS 4.0, measurement model assessment, structural model evaluation, bootstrapping, and mediation analysis; and descriptive and reliability analysis using Python.

Discussion of the results, theoretical and administrative ramifications, constraints, and potential future study avenues will all be included in the final report. The pilot study (April–May 2026), primary data collecting (June–August 2026), comprehensive analysis and report writing (August–September 2026), and final presentation (October 2026) comprise the entire timetable.

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ANNEXURE I

Survey Questionnaire: Influencer Authenticity and AI Content in Digital Marketing

All items (except demographics) use a five-point scale: 1 = Strongly Disagree | 2 = Disagree | 3 = Neutral | 4 = Agree | 5 = Strongly Agree

Section A: Consent and Screening

1. I agree to participate in this survey. [Yes / No]

2. Do you follow any social media influencer? [Yes / No]

3. Have you encountered influencer-promoted content in the past 6 months? [Yes / No / Not sure]

Section B: Demographics

4. Age: [Below 18 / 19–24 / 25–34 / 35–44 / 45+]

5. Gender: [Male / Female / Other / Prefer not to say]

6. How often do you use social media? [Multiple times daily / Daily / Several times a week / Weekly / Rarely]

7. Which platforms do you use most? [Instagram / YouTube / Twitter-X / LinkedIn / TikTok / Other]

Section C: Perceived Authenticity (PA)

PA1. The influencers I follow create content that feels genuine and personal.

PA2. I believe the influencers I follow share their real opinions about products.

PA3. The content from my favourite influencers feels natural, not scripted.

PA4. I trust that the influencers I follow are being true to themselves in their posts.

Section D: AI Content Awareness (ACA)

ACA1. I can often tell when an influencer's content has been created using AI tools.

ACA2. I frequently suspect that influencer posts are written or edited by AI.

ACA3. I am aware that many influencers now use AI tools like ChatGPT or Midjourney to create content.

ACA4. When content looks too polished or perfect, I assume AI was involved.

Section E: Content Transparency (CT)

CT1. I appreciate when influencers openly disclose that they used AI tools to create content.

CT2. Influencers who are transparent about their content creation process earn more of my respect.

CT3. Clear disclosure of AI usage in influencer content makes me trust the influencer more.

CT4. I prefer influencers who are honest about sponsorships and AI assistance over those who hide it.

Section F: Parasocial Relationship (PSR)

PSR1. I feel like I know the influencers I follow personally.

PSR2. When I watch/read content from my favourite influencer, I feel like I am spending time with a friend.

PSR3. I look forward to seeing new content from the influencers I follow.

PSR4. I feel emotionally connected to the influencers I regularly follow.

Section G: Consumer Skepticism (CS)

CS1. I am skeptical about the sincerity of influencer product recommendations.

CS2. I question whether influencers truly use the products they promote.

CS3. I believe most influencer content is designed primarily to sell, not to inform.

CS4. I doubt the honesty of influencer reviews when I suspect AI involvement.

Section H: Brand Credibility (BC)

BC1. Brands promoted by authentic influencers seem more trustworthy to me.

BC2. I consider a brand more credible when it is recommended by an influencer I trust.

BC3. Influencer endorsements make me perceive the brand as more reliable and competent.

Section I: Purchase Intention (PI)

PI1. After seeing an influencer recommendation I trust, I am more likely to purchase the product.

PI2. I would consider buying a product sooner because an influencer I follow recommended it.

PI3. I would choose a product recommended by a trusted influencer over alternatives.

Section J: Quality Check

QC1. I carefully read the questions in this survey. [Strongly Agree expected]

Section K: Open-Ended (Optional)

Please describe a memorable experience where you felt an influencer’s content was either genuinely authentic or suspiciously AI-generated. What made you feel that way?